While the National COVID-19 task force, the empowered groups and all arms of the government were fighting on a war footing against an invisible, unknown and unpredictable enemy, our soldiers stationed in the Galwan Valley along the 3,488-km-long Sino–Indian border engaged in a violent face-off with the People's Liberation Army's (PLA) forces: a first since the 1962 India–China War. This stand-off would have long-term consequences on India's bilateral relationship with China as well on the Indian political psyche to focus on reducing dependability on China in trade. Eventually, India's atmanirbharta would enable us to significantly improve our position in the global supply chains which were reforming due to the pandemic. In fact, in the first state visit to India post-pandemic, when the Prime Minister of Denmark Mette Frederiksen gave her remarks to the press, she noted, 'Can't rely solely on China, India needs to become part of global supply chain,' echoing sentiments of several other world leaders.[1]

The Galwan River Valley, with its harsh climate and high-altitude terrain, has more or less been peaceful despite being in the disputed Himalayan border region. The clash occurred during the night time hours along the Galwan River, which originates from Aksai Chin, a disputed area claimed by India, but controlled by China, reaching the Shyok River.[2] At a certain point along the route, at a height of 14,000 ft on a steep terrain, the river takes a sharp left turn before merging with Shyok. Patrol Point 14 (PP14) is just a little bit ahead of this confluence and has traditionally been a point up until where Indian and Chinese troops regularly and jointly patrolled. However, a structure has never been built at this level due to bipartisan understanding. Since over a month, tension had been building up around this point: the Chinese first built up a tent along this point in an area considered to be part of the Indian territory and attempted to trek down the Shyok River. After confrontation by the Indian troops, they dismantled the tent and retreated. However, after this one-off event, both sides built up troops at their camps near PP14, raising tension in the area. Early in June, a meeting was held between the Indian Corps Commander and his Chinese counterpart where it was decided that both sides would retreat by two kilometres from their current positions in order to maintain peace in the area. Both troops retreated accordingly. But in a few days, the Indians discovered that the Chinese had once again built two structures on a slope leading down to the river, one of which seemed to be an observation point. The Commanding Officer held talks with his counterpart and agreed that